Lesson 31: Narrative Paragraphs 2: Descriptive Details, Model Paragraphs and Writing

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from Building Academic Writing Skills by Lin Cui, Harper College (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0): Unit 5 Narrative Paragraphs, sections VI. Descriptive Vocabulary and Details in Narration to VIII. Unit Review Practice: Writing Assignments.

In this lesson

This lesson completes Lesson 30. You will learn to replace general words with specific, descriptive ones, check the parts of a narrative with color coding, analyze more student paragraphs and correct two weak ones. Then you will write your own narrative paragraph, the book's writing assignment. Choosing precise words and checking your own paragraph against a list are skills you will use in all your academic writing.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Replace general words (big, bad, walk, look) with specific, descriptive vocabulary.
- Add details to the middle of a narrative so that the reader can "see" the event.
- Find the parts of a narrative paragraph and correct problems with the controlling idea, order, relevance, transitions and tenses.
- Plan, write and revise a narrative paragraph with the writing process.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
descriptive vocabulary	specific words that help the reader "see" or "picture" an event	They have a 2-story, red brick house.
sensory words	words that describe sight, sound, smell, flavor and feeling	scrumptious, whisper, glimpse
details	specific facts and descriptions that support the main idea	Details are the key to interesting paragraphs.
color coding	marking each part of a paragraph in a different color to check it	Color code Paragraph "My Memorable Interview".
irrelevant	not connected to the main idea	If anything is irrelevant, cross it out.
stumble (verb)	walk unsteadily, as if going to fall (book)	An eighty-seven-year-old man stumbled along Algonquin Road.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
vividly (adverb)	lively and brightly (book)	The second sentence helps the reader "see" the house more vividly.
critical (adjective)	extremely important (book)	Details in the middle of the narration are even more critical.
scrumptious (adjective)	delicious (book)	It looked scrumptious.
awful (adjective)	terrible (book)	This situation was awful.
attentive (adjective)	giving careful attention (book)	My future husband was very attentive.
diligence (noun)	good efforts (book)	I gave him one star for diligence.

Rules and explanations

Choose specific, descriptive words

Words are your tools. In each pair, the second sentence is better because the reader can "see" the house, the man and Mrs. Kim more vividly:

- They have a large house. → They have a 2-story, red brick house.
- An old man walked on the street. → An eighty-seven-year-old man stumbled along Algonquin Road.
- Mrs. Kim is the best teacher I have ever had. → Mrs. Kim is the most humorous and hardworking teacher I have ever had.

General words like *big, good, nice, great, bad* can be replaced by better ones. Many of these are sensory words:

General	Descriptive
afraid	fearful, frightened, petrified, scared, terrified
ask/say/tell	beg, command, instruct, murmur, order, plead, whisper, wonder
bad	damaging, detrimental, disadvantageous, harmful, negative
big	bulky, colossal, enormous, gigantic, huge, immense, massive, vast
delicious	appetizing, flavorful, rich, mouth-watering, savory, scrumptious, succulent
happy	cheerful, content, delighted, ecstatic, elated, exhilarated, joyful
important	critical, crucial, essential, life-changing, momentous, significant, vital, weighty
look	gaze, glance, glare, glimpse, inspect, marvel, peep, stare
nervous	anxious, concerned, fretful, uneasy, unsettled, worried

General	Descriptive
walk	hop, ramble, scamper, scuttle, stride, stroll, strut, stumble, tiptoe

Before you use a new word, check its exact meaning in an English-English dictionary. Try to use two or three new descriptive words in each paragraph.

Details and color coding

Details are the key to interesting paragraphs, and details in the **middle** (how the story progresses) are even more critical. Color coding helps you check that the paragraph has all the essential parts, that they are in the right order, and which parts need to be longer. The book's colors: title: pink; background information: purple; topic sentence and concluding sentence(s): red; beginning and end of the story: green; middle of the story: blue; transitions: yellow. The middle should be the longest part.

Checking a narrative paragraph

Section VII of the unit gives six more student models ("My First Conversation Class", "My Most Angry Experience", "A Dangerous Night in La Cross, Wisconsin", "A Valuable Approach", "A Lesson about Curiosity", "My Most Relaxing Morning"). Read them with these questions: Does the topic sentence have a controlling idea? Does the background give what, who, when and where? Are the events in chronological order? Does all the information support the main idea? Is the middle the longest part? When the writer changes from the past to a present or future tense, why? (Usually for a lesson or a habit that is true now: *Every fear is temporary*.)

Practice

1. Exercise 5: Descriptive vocabulary. Write a new sentence: replace the word in bold (underlined in the book) with a descriptive word from the table. Example: The family carried the **big** mattress into the **small** apartment. → The family carried the bulky mattress into the one-bedroom apartment.

1. The **big** cruise ship has 18 decks and is 1188 feet long.
2. My upcoming interview is going to be **important** to my career.
3. The family made a **big** decision to immigrant to the U.S. one year ago.
4. The mother **walked** into the baby's room quietly.
5. The graduates **walked** proudly onto the stage to receive their diploma.
6. Some parents have a **bad** influence on their children.
7. In darkness, I was very **afraid** when I heard a strange noise behind me.
8. I love **looking** at the stars in the night sky.
9. The mom said no, but the boy still **asked** for more ice cream.
10. The students are **nervous** about their grades.

2. Exercise 6: Color code "My Memorable Interview". Read it again in your lesson material (Lesson 30) and mark the parts (colors or labels): title, topic sentence, background information, beginning, middle and end of the story, transitions, concluding sentence(s). Then answer: a) Which color covers the most information? b) How does the part in blue help you "see" what the writer was

going through? c) Underline the descriptive or specific vocabulary. How does it make the paragraph more interesting?

3. Exercise 7: Two weak paragraphs. Read "My Parking Lot Nightmare" (#1) and "My Busy Holiday" (#2) in your lesson material. For each paragraph, answer: a) Is there a topic sentence with a controlling idea? If not, write one. b) Does the background information include what, who, when and where? c) Are the events in chronological order? If not, correct the order. d) Is any information irrelevant? Cross it out. e) Are the transitions appropriate? Add any that are missing. f) Are the past tenses correct? Why are there present tenses? g) What details could you add to the middle?

Speak with your tutor

- "Say ten general words, like big, bad, walk and look, one at a time. I will replace each with a descriptive word from Lesson 31 and use it in a sentence about my own life."
- "Read me the meanings of the Unit 5 vocabulary cards one at a time (scrumptious, awful, despondent, a rocky start, exhausting, superficially, elaborately, approach, irresponsibly, assume, diligence, attentive, genie, transform, stumble, vividly, critical). I will say the word."
- "Ask me the section VII questions about the model 'A Lesson about Curiosity' and correct my answers."
- "Here is my outline: [paste]. Check my controlling idea, my background information and the order of the events."
- "Here is my narrative paragraph: [paste]. Check it against the Lesson 31 checklist, then list my grammar errors by type, especially past tenses."

Writing task

The book's assignment. Write two narrative paragraphs on two different topics; start the second one after the first one is complete.

- **Topic:** choose one: your first class experience at your college (in the book: Harper College); a time when you helped someone in need; your proudest moment; your most embarrassing experience; a disappointing shopping trip; an experience where you got to know yourself better; an experience where you got to know another person better; an experience that changed your opinion of an event; an interview you had (any kind); the day when you got your first cell phone. For a topic of your own (for example, the story you planned in Lesson 30), discuss it with your tutor first.
- **Brainstorm and outline:** your topic, controlling idea and background (what, when, where, who); the topic sentence with background in 1 to 3 complete sentences; notes (or a timeline) for the beginning, middle and end.
- **Paragraph:** a title, a topic sentence, background information, the beginning of the story, the middle with details, the end, a conclusion and appropriate time transitions. Include at least 5 words from the descriptive vocabulary table. Length: about 250 to 400 words, like the student models.

- **Format:** typed, double spaced, font size 12, 1-inch margins; your name, class and date in the upper right-hand corner; the first line indented.

Self-editing checklist (from the book's Self Checklist):

1. Does my topic sentence have a clear controlling idea?
2. Did I give what, who, when and where in the beginning?
3. Do I have a beginning, a middle (the longest part) and an ending, in chronological order with proper time expressions?
4. Do all my details support the main idea, and are they interesting and descriptive?
5. Did I use proper past tenses, and do all my verbs agree with their subjects?
6. Did I use correct sentence structure (simple, compound, complex), spelling, punctuation and capitalization?
7. Did I use at least 5 words from the descriptive vocabulary table?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Extra (the book's NSNT practice): choose two prompts from the NSNT appendix (Lesson 1), write a paragraph for each, then revise them with this checklist.

Answer key

1. Exercise 5 (example answer; some other words from the same row of the table may also fit: ask your tutor)

1. The colossal / enormous / gigantic / massive cruise ship has 18 decks and is 1188 feet long.
2. My upcoming interview is going to be crucial / critical / vital / essential to my career.
3. The family made a huge / momentous / life-changing decision to immigrate to the U.S. one year ago. (The book writes "immigrant", a noun; the verb is "immigrate".)
4. The mother tiptoed into the baby's room quietly.
5. The graduates strode / strutted proudly onto the stage to receive their diploma.
6. Some parents have a harmful / negative / damaging / detrimental influence on their children.
7. In darkness, I was terrified / petrified when I heard a strange noise behind me. (Leave out "very" with these strong words; "very frightened" or "very scared" is fine.)
8. I love gazing at / marveling at the stars in the night sky.
9. The mom said no, but the boy still begged / pleaded for more ice cream.
10. The students are anxious / worried / concerned / uneasy about their grades.

2. Exercise 6 (parts: the borders can differ a little)

- Topic sentence: "In my last year of high school in Japan, I learned an important lesson from a memorable interview." Background: the next three sentences (the application and the assigned book). Beginning: the preparation, from "One month before the interview, ...". Middle: from "In the middle of February, ..." to "They nodded to me and to each other." End: "That afternoon, I flew back home, feeling happy." Concluding sentences: the last three, from "From this experience, ...".
- Transitions (book, underlined): One month before the interview, / then / In the middle of February, / The interview day arrived. / As soon as my name was called, / when five cards were put side by side on the table, / During the interview, / At the end of the interview, / At that time, / That afternoon,
- a) Blue (the middle). b) It shows the scene and the writer's feelings step by step: chills because of tension, six professors across the table, five cards side by side, "It was like a card game!". c) (example answer) superficially, chills, tension, strain, impressed, jumped for joy, elaborately: they make the reader feel the writer's stress and then joy.

3. Exercise 7

1 "My Parking Lot Nightmare"

- a) No: "It was in the early afternoon of January 21, 2015." gives only the time. (example answer) *Finding my car in a Harper College parking lot on January 21, 2015 was a nightmare.*
- b) When, where and who are there, but *what* (the lost car) is missing from the beginning; the new topic sentence adds it.

- c) No: "My backpack was very heavy. I had to carry it while looking for my car." comes after the car is found. Move it to the middle, after "... but still could not find my car."
- d) Nothing is clearly irrelevant; the backpack sentences are only in the wrong place.
- e) (example answer) Add *From that day on,* before "I always check the parking lot number twice ...".
- f) "I cannot find my car" → *could not find*; "I do not know what to do" → *did not know*. The present tenses at the end are correct: "I always check ..." is a habit now, and "I have not had a problem ... in the past 2 years" covers the time from then until now.
- g) (example answer) the cold January weather, what the parking lots looked like, the writer's feelings (panicked, terrified).

2 "My Busy Holiday"

- a) Yes: "Thanksgiving Day in 2018 was a busy day for me because many relatives came to my house for dinner." Controlling idea: busy.
- b) Yes: Thanksgiving dinner; many relatives and I; Thanksgiving Day 2018; my house. c) Yes.
- d) Cross out "Black Friday is a good time to get deals, and once I even bought a 48-inch TV for less than $500."
- e) (example answer) Add a transition before "We started dinner.", for example *Then* or *At 7 pm,*.
- f) "We hug each other and say" → *hugged*, *said*; "the children continue" → *continued*; "I feel exhausted and go to sleep" → *felt*, *went*. ("were talking" is possible, but *talked* matches *gathered*.) "had bought" is correct: it happened two days before. Nothing explains these present tenses, so use the past.
- g) (example answer) the smell of the roasted turkey, the names of the relatives, the games.

My notes